Haus of Taste: A UX Design Case Study

Project: Haus of Taste (Mobile Application)

Role: UX/UI Designer & Researcher

Timeline: 6 Weeks

Platform: iOS & Android Mobile App

OVERVIEW & DIAMOND 1 – DISCOVER (Understanding the Problem)

1. Project Summary & Background

Haus of Taste is a mobile application designed to uncover "hidden gem" restaurants in major South African cities (Johannesburg, Cape Town, Durban, etc.). The primary product-use context centers around dating enthusiasts who want to experience the best, most unique culinary scenes their cities have to offer.

The application bridges the gap between discovery and execution. It provides robust filtering options (mood, cuisine, budget), seamless table reservations, integrated map navigation, and a personalized user dashboard for curating, reviewing, and sharing favorite spots.

2. Empathize & Research Process

To avoid "tunnel vision" and selection bias (as noted in the UCT guidelines), the research phase began with a carefully crafted screening survey. We targeted users who actively go on dates and dine out at least twice a month, filtering out users who solely rely on fast food or delivery apps.

User Persona: "The Planner" (Thabo)

Demographics: 28 years old, Young Professional based in Johannesburg.

Motivations: Wants to impress his dates with unique, intimate dining experiences rather than commercialized, crowded restaurant chains.

Frustrations: Spends hours cross-referencing Instagram, Google Reviews, and booking sites. Often struggles to find places that match a specific "mood" or budget on the fly.

Requirements: Needs a centralized platform to discover, vet, book, and navigate to hidden gems effortlessly.

3. Usage Hypothesis

Common Usage: A user opens the app on a Thursday evening, uses the "Mood" (e.g., Intimate/Romantic) and "Budget" filters, reads a review, and books a table for Friday night.

Uncommon Usage: A user utilizes the dashboard purely as a digital diary to curate private lists of places they've visited and edit past reviews, without actively using the booking feature.

DIAMOND 1 – DEFINE (Synthesize & Align)

1. Problem Statement & Design Frame

Problem Statement: South African dating enthusiasts face cognitive overload and friction when trying to discover, validate, and book unique, mood-specific restaurants across fragmented platforms.

How Might We (HMW): How might we provide a seamless, end-to-end date planning experience that empowers users to discover, book, and curate hidden culinary gems in South Africa?

2. Stakeholder Alignment & Mental Model Diagram

In early stakeholder meetings, a conflict in objectives emerged. The business stakeholders wanted to maximize social sharing and public reviews to drive app virality. However, our initial user research indicated that users wanted to keep "hidden gems" a secret to maintain their exclusivity.

We used a Mental Model Diagram to map user requirements against interface affordances, finding a compromise.

User Requirement: Curate private lists of date spots.

Business Goal: Increase app engagement and restaurant visibility.

Compromise: The dashboard was designed to allow users to create both Private ("My Secret Spots") and Public curated lists. This satisfied the user's need for privacy while allowing stakeholders to benefit from shareable public guides (e.g., "Top 5 Romantic Spots in Cape Town").

3. The Hypothesis Evaluation Matrix (HEM)

To objectively discard irrelevant information and avoid "abusing the evidence," we utilized the Hypothesis Evaluation Matrix (HEM) to test a core assumption regarding the in-app map navigation.

Hypothesis 1: Users want a proprietary, built-in GPS navigation system within Haus of Taste.

Hypothesis 2: Users prefer the app to hand-off navigation to their native OS apps (Google Maps/Apple Maps).

Evidence Gathered: "Users expressed frustration when forced to learn a new map interface." -> Highly Consistent with H2 / Inconsistent with H1.

Phase Shift: We discarded the idea of building a custom GPS. Instead, the interface affordance was updated to feature a simple "Navigate There" button that seamlessly bridges to Google Maps/Waze via API, reducing the app's cognitive load.

DIAMOND 2 – DEVELOP (Ideate & Design)

1. Information Architecture (IA) & User Journey

We structured the IA to ensure high learnability for first-time users and efficiency for returning users. The core user-path is structured as follows:

Home Feed: Geo-located hidden gems and curated public lists.

Search/Filter: Granular toggles for Mood, Cuisine, Budget, and Distance.

Restaurant Profile: High-quality imagery, user reviews, and an integrated "Book Now" widget.

Dashboard: A profile hub to edit user details, write reviews, view favorited restaurants, and manage curated lists.

2. Aesthetic Context & Visual Design Principles

Following the principles of Gestalt psychology and visual aesthetics, the interface was designed to evoke a sense of exclusivity, romance, and appetite.

Color Theory: The primary color palette utilizes deep burgundies and warm ambient golds against a dark-mode background. Psychologically, deep reds stimulate appetite and passion, while the dark UI mimics the sophisticated, low-lighting ambiance of an intimate date night.

The Rule of Thirds & Golden Ratio: Restaurant profile cards were designed using the Golden Ratio to ensure aesthetically pleasing proportions. Food and venue photography is strictly curated to align with the Rule of Thirds, ensuring the visual focal points naturally draw the user's eye.

Visual Hierarchy: Size and color contrast were used to guide the user-path. The "Book Table" button is the largest, most vibrant element (high contrast) on the restaurant screen, acting as the primary Call-To-Action (CTA).

Symmetry and Asymmetry: The homepage grid uses translational symmetry to display restaurant cards, making it easy for the eye to scan. Asymmetry is introduced in the "Featured Gem of the Week" banner to intentionally break the pattern and draw immediate focus.

DIAMOND 2 – DELIVER (Prototype & Test)

1. Interactive Prototyping

Wireframes were developed into a high-fidelity, interactive clickthrough prototype. The prototype contained over 15 interactive elements, focusing specifically on the filtering system, the booking flow, and the profile dashboard.

2. Usability Testing Methodology

As per the Nielsen Norman Group research cited in the UCT notes ("Less is statistically more"), we recruited 5 representative users for qualitative testing, which is sufficient to uncover approximately 85% of usability issues.

Documentation: Tests were recorded using screencasting software (OBS) to capture real-time footage of user interactions.

Protocol: We utilized the "Think Out Loud" method. Users were asked to narrate their thought process (e.g., "I am clicking the heart icon because I want to save this for later") to provide insight into their cognitive mapping.

3. Usability Metrics Evaluated

Learnability: How quickly a first-time user could locate a restaurant using the "Mood" filter (e.g., selecting "Cozy").

Efficiency: How fast an experienced user could navigate to their dashboard, access a saved list, and initiate a booking.

Error-Resistance: Ensuring that users could easily undo a booking mistake (e.g., selecting the wrong time) before final confirmation, utilizing redundant fail-safes.

FINDINGS, ITERATIONS & CONCLUSION

1. The System Usability Scale (SUS) Results

Following the user tests, participants were asked to complete the 10-item System Usability Scale.

Average SUS Score: 84/100.

Analysis: A score of 84 is well above the industry average of 68, indicating that Haus of Taste possesses strong usability and high user confidence. Users strongly agreed with the statement, "I thought the system was easy to use," particularly praising the intuitive nature of the Mood filters.

2. Key Findings & Design Iterations

Despite the high SUS score, the "Think Out Loud" recordings and contextual cues revealed three areas requiring intervention:

Issue 1: Dashboard Clutter.

Finding: Users found the dashboard overwhelming. The "Edit Profile," "My Reviews," and "Curated Lists" elements were competing for visual dominance.

Iteration: We adjusted the visual hierarchy. We used negative space to separate "Account Settings" from "Social Features." We introduced a tabbed navigation system within the dashboard to separate "Favorites" from "My Reviews."

Issue 2: Booking Friction.

Finding: Users wanted to check the menu while on the booking confirmation screen to ensure it fit their budget, but navigating back caused them to lose their selected time slot.

Iteration: We improved error-resistance by implementing a split-screen/pop-up modal for the booking widget. This allows users to scroll through the restaurant's background details and menu without losing their active booking state.

Issue 3: Redundancy in Navigation.

Finding: Users sometimes missed the Map icon on the restaurant page.

Iteration: We applied the UX principle of Redundancy. We added a textual cue ("Get Directions") alongside the visual Map icon, and placed a secondary navigation link on the final booking confirmation page to assist the user journey.

3. Conclusion

The Haus of Taste UX project successfully synthesized complex stakeholder goals with deep user empathy. By rigorously applying the Double Diamond framework, testing our usage hypotheses via the HEM, and utilizing strong visual hierarchy and Gestalt principles, the resulting prototype is both highly functional and aesthetically engaging.

The application effectively solves the cognitive overload of date-planning. It allows users to seamlessly discover hidden gems based on hyper-specific moods, reliably book tables, and comfortably curate their culinary experiences in a beautifully designed digital environment.